

The 6:15

FRIDAY · SEPTEMBER 18, 2026

NO. 15

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS) · CATCH-UP ISSUE, NO. 14 RAN 9/12

Fri 9/18

FedEx reports fiscal Q1 after today's close; no consensus figure verified this run **[not verified]**. Sat 9/19: Northwestern (1-0) hosts Colorado (2-0), 6:30p CT, favored by 3.5 — last game at Northwestern Medicine Field at Martin Stadium before the move to Ryan Field.

Wk of 9/22

Durable goods, final Q2 GDP, existing home sales clustered ~9/25; initial claims ~9/25; PCE (Fed's preferred gauge) ~9/26 — all dates from a single weekly preview, not cross-checked against BLS/BEA calendars **[dates indicative, not confirmed]**. Next FOMC meeting date not located this run **[not confirmed]**.

[DEVELOPING]

The Oman-brokered Salalah meeting flagged in issue No. 14 as scheduled for Mon. 9/14 was postponed indefinitely — see Lead and Iran & Hormuz.

No verified rocket-launch, AI-model, or VC-funding item from the prior 24-48h located this run; sub-bullet skipped rather than padded.

METRICS · AS OF THU 9/17 CLOSE UNLESS NOTED

Oil/rates/vol

Brent \$102.57 (-2.2%, third straight losing session, ~7:40a ET Fri — no settle yet); WTI ~\$100.05 (-1.9%, same read), down from Wed's \$102.43 settle and Thu's ~\$101.34. 10Y 4.94% (-8bp); 2Y and 30Y not confirmed as of press time **[unverified]**. VIX 17.71 (+3% Thu, despite the equity rally below) **[read: two-sided risk still priced]**.

Equities/FX/other

Dow 51,778.04 (+316.14, +0.61%, Thu); S&P 500 7,637.72 (+1.12%); Nasdaq Comp. 26,418 (+1.69%) — third straight advance. DXY ~100.23, dollar's first close above 100 in ~7 weeks. Gold quotes diverge, \$4,310.80-4,364.63/oz depending on snapshot **[not reconciled]**. Retail gas \$4.4386/gal natl. avg (AAA,

Wed 9/16), +16¢ on the week. Nikkei 64,136.25 (+0.33%, Thu Tokyo close); FTSE 100 ~10,785, -0.3% Fri morning on Hormuz tension and BoE rate concerns.

Fri premarket futures	Two irreconcilable snapshots this run: Barchart's ES/NQ contracts show +0.49%/+0.15%; a separate roundup cites S&P futures +1.94%, Nasdaq futures +2.62%, tied to the Asia chip rally below. Not averaged or picked — treat the smaller move as the more likely read given Thursday's cash-market gains were already booked. [divergent, unresolved]
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Crude: ICE Brent/NYMEX WTI front-month. Rates: Fed H.15/CME. Equities: exchange closes/CNBC/Bloomberg.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure day	Tracker counts (straits.live, globalsecurity.org) not refreshed this run [gap] .
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Transits	Kpler figures diverge across sources located this run: one dataset shows 12 vessels crossed 9/16 (double 9/15's 6), 10-day avg. 17/day; another shows just 3 on 9/16, down from 12 the previous day, same 17/day average. Not reconciled.
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Dark tankers/AIS	straits.live's stranded-vessel series not refreshed since issue No. 14's 490 total — aging, not repeated as current.
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War-risk premia	General market reporting (Insurance Day, Lloyd's List, S&P Global) now frames premia as 3-10% of hull value per transit — e.g. ~\$21M on a \$210M VLCC at the high end — a different unit than issue No. 14's flat ~\$10.0M/VLCC straits.live figure. Not the same series; not netted.
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Strikes	Iranian state media said a commercial vessel was struck near Qeshm ~9/13, killing one; US CENTCOM called that account false and attributed the strike to an Iranian drone instead. Unreconciled [DEVELOPING] .
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Kpler's AIS averages, Lloyd's List's weekly aggregation, straits.live's snapshots, and the hull-value-percentage premia figures above all measure different things over different windows — never netted or averaged.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Split two vs. Minnesota (won 8-1 Tue 9/15, lost 4-5 Wed 9/16); 88-64, 2nd in the AL East, hold the top AL wild-card spot ahead of Boston (82-70) and the White Sox (77-75) [record via standings summary, not the live page] .
Knicks	Hart extension still unsigned; per NY Post's Bondy, front office isn't expected to sign Hart, Towns, or McBride before the season — Hart's 2027-28 team option removes urgency.
Northwestern	Hosts Colorado Sat. 9/19, 6:30p CT — see Calendar.

LEAD

THE FED HIKES FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE 2023 — AND THE MARKET RALLIES ANYWAY

The FOMC raises rates a quarter point to 3.75%-4%, its first increase in three years, and stocks post their best stretch in weeks as falling oil and a bullish Nvidia forecast overshadow tighter policy

The FOMC voted 12-0 on Wednesday to raise the federal funds target range by 25 basis points to 3.75%-4%, the first increase since 2023 and a reversal of the cutting bias that has otherwise defined this cycle. [fact] The move followed through on odds that had climbed above 85% after the hot core CPI and PPI prints this issue's prior edition covered; Fed official Kevin Warsh, briefing reporters after the decision, said inflation "is still too high," defending the hike even as the statement described spending as resilient, productivity as strong, and capital investment as robust — a Committee tightening from a position of growth strength, not weakness. [fact/quote] The accompanying dot plot showed 16 of 18 participants penciling in at least one further increase this cycle, four of those seeing two more;

markets are now pricing continued tightening rather than a pause.
[fact]

Equities did not treat the hike as a headwind. The session after the decision, Thursday, all three major averages extended their advance: the Dow rose 0.61% to 51,778.04, the S&P 500 gained 1.12% to 7,637.72, and the Nasdaq Composite added 1.69% to 26,418, a third straight day of gains. [fact] Oddly, the VIX rose 3% to 17.71 on the same session — a move that doesn't fit the simple "stocks up, vol down" script and suggests options markets are still pricing meaningful two-sided risk into next month rather than settling into complacency. [read] Two separate tailwinds look more responsible for the rally than the Fed decision itself. First, Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang told investors Thursday he expects the company to sell twice as many chips next year, re-igniting the AI capex trade, lifting Nvidia itself roughly 2% to around \$218 and pulling Samsung and SK Hynix higher into Friday's Asia session. [fact] Second, oil extended its slide for a third straight session — Brent down 2.2% to \$102.57 and WTI down 1.9% to roughly \$100.05 as of Friday morning — on reports of additional Saudi crude reaching global markets via Oman workarounds, even as the Gulf diplomacy that helped trigger last Friday's oil reversal stalled (see Iran & Hormuz).
[fact]

Put together, the mechanism looks like this: the Fed hiked into an inflation picture that was substantially an energy story, and the energy story is now unwinding on its own, independent of the rate decision, while a chip-demand narrative gives risk assets a reason to rally that has nothing to do with monetary policy either way. [read] That's the same "one meeting behind" risk flagged in issue No. 14, now sharper rather than resolved: if oil keeps falling through

October on supply workarounds rather than a real Hormuz settlement, a Fed that hiked on a shock already fading by the time it acted will have tightened into a softening inflation impulse, a mismatch the dot plot's four-hikes-pending signal makes more consequential, not less. [read] The dollar's move to a seven-week high post-hike adds a second-order channel worth watching — a stronger dollar and higher policy rate pulling against EM and multinational earnings translation even as the S&P celebrates a hardware-demand story. [read] There's a consumer-facing version of the same tension: a 25bp hike raises the floor under variable-rate borrowing (credit cards, HELOCs, adjustable mortgages) just as retail gasoline rose 16 cents on the week and Lennar cut its delivery guidance for the second straight quarter (see Business) — tighter policy and softer housing arriving together rather than one easing the other. [read] None of this is resolved: the next FOMC meeting's date was not confirmed this run, and whether Nvidia's Thursday pop survives a full trading session — rather than a premarket or single-day reaction, the pattern that reversed both Oracle's and Adobe's post-earnings moves two issues ago — is an open question this issue will track into next week. [flag]

POLITICS

Delaware's Sept. 15 Democratic Senate primary — the last of the 2026 primary cycle, as flagged in issue No. 14 — went to the frontrunner: incumbent Chris Coons defeated three challengers (AI-systems builder Jeff Appelhans, business executive Eric Hansen, and small-business owner Mary Louve) with roughly 84% of the vote, called by the AP within minutes of polls closing. [fact] Coons advances to face Republican Dr. Mike Katz in November. [fact] With that contest decided, the 2026 primary calendar this issue has

tracked since spring is now closed; coverage shifts to the general-election map for subsequent issues. [NEW] Delaware's Senate seat is not considered competitive in a general-election sense — Coons is the heavy favorite against Katz in November — so the practical significance of Tuesday's result is calendar-clearing rather than a shift in the chamber's competitive math; this issue is not aware of a verified rating change from a nonpartisan handicapper this run. [flag] No other primary or special-election development was located this run.

ECONOMICS

The Lead covers Wednesday's hike itself; this section carries the forward path. The dot plot showed 16 of 18 FOMC participants expecting at least one further increase this cycle and four of those expecting two more — a signal that Sept. 16 was not a one-and-done move, though the date of the next meeting was not independently confirmed this run. [flag] On the data calendar, initial jobless claims are penciled for around Sept. 25 and the Fed's preferred PCE inflation gauge for around Sept. 26, alongside durable goods orders, the final Q2 GDP revision, and existing home sales clustered near the same date — all from a single weekly-preview source not cross-checked against BLS or BEA's own calendars, so treat the dates as indicative rather than confirmed. [flag] The 2-year and 30-year Treasury yields were both unconfirmed as of press time; that matters more than usual this issue because the shape of the curve — whether the short end is repricing harder than the long end, as it did around last issue's CPI shock — is the cleanest signal of whether the market reads Wednesday's hike as a one-off inflation response or the start of a sustained tightening path, and this run can't confirm it either way. [flag] Retail gasoline rose 16 cents on the week to a \$4.4386/gal

national average even as futures fell for three straight sessions, a reminder that pump prices lag crude and that the energy relief showing up in wholesale markets hasn't reached drivers yet. [fact] On the borrowing side, Wednesday's hike raises the reference rate under variable-rate consumer debt — credit cards, HELOCs, adjustable mortgages — while savings and money-market yields move the same direction; no bank has published updated prime-rate or CD figures verified this run, so the pass-through magnitude isn't quantified here. [flag]

BUSINESS

Lennar missed on both lines Wednesday — EPS of \$1.19 against a \$1.29 consensus, revenue of \$8.05B versus \$8.31B expected and down 9% from \$8.81B a year earlier — and cut its full-year delivery target to 80,000-81,000 homes, down from the 82,000-83,000 it had guided to as recently as last quarter, citing rate pressure and deteriorating conditions through the quarter. [NEW] It is the builder's second consecutive guidance cut, landing the same week the Fed hiked rather than cut — a headwind extended, not relieved. [read] FedEx reports fiscal Q1 results after today's close; no consensus figure was verified this run, so none is printed here — next issue will carry the actual print. [flag] The two prints bracket the same question from opposite ends of the economy: Lennar's guidance cut is a demand-side read on rate-sensitive housing, while FedEx's package volumes are typically read as a broader freight/consumer-spending proxy; a soft FedEx print on top of Wednesday's hike and Lennar's miss would be the clearest sign yet that tighter policy is biting before inflation has clearly turned. [read]

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia's Jensen Huang told investors Thursday he expects the company to sell twice as many chips next year, a forecast that lifted Nvidia itself roughly 2% to around \$218 for a second straight gain and carried into Friday's Asia session, lifting Samsung Electronics, SK Hynix, and other regional chipmakers and contributing to a 0.8% rise in MSCI's broader Asian equities gauge. [fact] It's the same demand-outpacing-supply narrative that briefly lifted Oracle's cloud-backlog beat two issues ago before a full trading session gave the entire premarket move back; whether Huang's forecast holds up past Thursday's single session, rather than reversing the way Oracle's did, is the open question this issue is tracking into next week. [read] Huang's doubled-demand comment is a verbal forecast made to investors, not a revised SEC filing or formal guidance update; it builds on the roughly 70% revenue-growth figure Nvidia projected for its coming fiscal year last month, with Thursday's remark suggesting upside to that number if production capacity keeps pace — a capacity caveat that has been the recurring constraint on the AI-hardware trade all year and is not resolved by Thursday's comments alone. [read]

GEOPOLITICS

Russia struck the Zaporizhstal steel works with two ballistic missiles Thursday morning and hit Zaporizhzhia city in a broader wave Ukrainian officials said killed at least one person and injured 18 or more, part of what President Zelensky called an "aerial terror" campaign — more than 3,500 drones and nearly 190 missiles launched at Ukraine so far in September alone, by his tally. [fact/quote, single-sourced to Zelensky's own statement] Ukrainian forces continued matching strikes on Russian military infrastructure, including S-400 launchers and UAV launch sites, overnight into Sept. 17. [fact] A separate report of 10 killed and 75 injured nationwide across Kyiv, Zaporizhzhia, and Odesa oblasts over roughly the same window was not reconciled against the Zaporizhzhia-specific toll above and may overlap with it rather than add to it. [flag] No development was located this run on the Ukraine-Canada partnership agreement or the Witkoff-Kushner channel flagged in issue No. 14. [continuity] The pattern across the gap since issue No. 14 is one of continued intensity rather than escalation or de-escalation: neither side's territorial position was reported to have shifted materially in the sourcing reviewed this run, and Zelensky's own framing — an "aerial terror" campaign measured in monthly drone and missile totals rather than front-line movement — suggests the war's current phase is being fought more through infrastructure attrition than through maneuver. [read]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The Oman-brokered meeting flagged in issue No. 14 as scheduled for Monday, Sept. 14, in Salalah — Gulf foreign ministers and Iran's

Abbas Araqchi discussing a temporary arrangement routing ships into the strait via Iranian waters and out via Omani waters — was postponed indefinitely; Omani FM Badr Albusaidi said only that the postponement was "in the interests of consensus," without elaborating. [NEW] Diplomats briefed on the effort say a full reopening still requires a separate US-Iran understanding, with Washington wanting any deal to also address Iran's nuclear program and Tehran wanting the port blockade lifted and oil exports resumed — a gap that predates and outlasts Monday's non-meeting. [fact] Separately, Iranian state media claimed a commercial vessel was struck near Qeshm around Sept. 13, killing one crew member; US Central Command called the Iranian account false and attributed the strike to an Iranian drone instead — the two narratives remain unreconciled. [DEVELOPING] Transit and war-risk figures are in the Board; see that section's note on why the counters diverge further than usual this issue. Taken together with the Lead's market angle, the picture across the gap is of a diplomatic track that moved backward (the postponed Salalah meeting) while the physical situation stayed contested (the disputed Qeshm strike) even as oil prices moved lower anyway — a reminder that this run's price action has tracked reported diplomacy and alternate-supply routes more than it has tracked the underlying security situation in the strait itself. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees	Split two vs. Twins (W 8-1 Tue, L 4-5 Wed). 88-64; top AL wild card, 2nd in AL East.
Knicks	Hart extension still unsigned — no urgency per Bondy; unchanged.
Northwestern	Hosts Colorado (2-0) Sat. 9/19, 6:30p CT, favored by 3.5.

Gap notice. No issue ran Sept. 13-17; this catch-up issue (No. 15) spans that full window rather than a single 24-hour cycle, so some items reflect several days of movement rather than overnight change.

Continuity. Not refreshed this run: Hormuz closure-day trackers; the stranded-vessel/dark-tanker count; Nvidia-Hugging Face deal; Amazon FTC ad-auction suit; Ford/CATL battery scrutiny; Anthropic IPO timeline; Starship Flight 14's date split; the OpenAI-Anthropic Navier-Stokes dispute (no new development located). Watch for next issue: FedEx's print after today's close; whether Nvidia's Thursday move survives a full session; the next FOMC meeting's date; reconciliation of Kpler's conflicting Sept. 16 transit counts; any US-Iran development following the Salalah postponement; corroboration of Thursday's Ukraine casualty tallies.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.